

Week 11: Andragogy, Adult Learning, and AI in Education

Article Summaries

Loeng (2018): A History of Andragogy

Loeng traces the concept of andragogy from its origins with Alexander Kapp in 1833 through European traditions to Malcolm Knowles's popularization in America. The article reveals how andragogy emerged in European contexts focused on social healing after World War I—particularly in the work of Rosenstock-Huessy who sought to bridge divided groups—while Knowles transformed it into an individualistic framework centered on self-actualization and career advancement. Loeng critiques Knowles for creating a false dichotomy between pedagogy and andragogy by strawmanning pedagogy as purely authoritarian and teacher-centered. This narrow definition allowed Knowles to position andragogy as revolutionary when, in reality, both terms encompass richer traditions of learning across the lifespan. The article argues that differences between child and adult learning are matters of degree rather than kind, challenging the need for separate paradigms.

Key Quote: "A somewhat extreme way of putting it would be to say that Knowles engaged in a relatively uncritical effort to update the prevailing social conditions" (p. 6). This captures how Knowles's andragogy naturalized American hyperindividualism rather than interrogating it. The article also cites Hartree noting that "Knowles was a modern individualist; therefore, it was important to him to contribute to individual self-realisation through career and lifestyle" (p. 6), revealing the cultural specificity of what Knowles presented as universal adult learning principles.

A competing definition from the Nottingham Andragogy Group offers a more liberatory vision: "Andragogy can be defined as an approach i.e. the total embodiment and expression of a philosophy of education for adults. This approach is aimed at enabling people to become aware that they should be the originators of their own thinking and feeling" (p. 4). This Freirean-influenced definition emphasizes agency and critical consciousness rather than vocational efficiency, suggesting alternative trajectories for the concept beyond Knowles's framework.

Chan (2010): Knowles's Six Assumptions of Andragogy

Chan examines Malcolm Knowles's six core assumptions that distinguish andragogy from traditional pedagogy: self-directedness, need to know, experience as a resource, readiness to learn, problem-centered orientation, and internal motivation. The article demonstrates how these assumptions have been applied across fields including management education, criminal justice training, police development, and medical education. However, Chan also presents important critiques, particularly the lack of cultural perspective and failure to consider social and political contexts. The article reveals how Knowles assumed all humans and cultures value Western ideals like individualism, self-realization, independence, and self-direction—universalizing particular cultural values as natural human characteristics. This critique exposes andragogy's colonial dimensions, showing how it exports American cultural assumptions globally under the guise of describing universal adult learning principles.

Key Quote: "Adult learners are self-directed, problem orient[ed], internally motivated, and independent learners" (p. 27). This quote crystallizes the false dichotomy at the heart of Knowles's framework. As discussed in our conversations, these aren't qualities that magically appear at age eighteen—they develop when we foster and encourage innate tendencies in children rather than systematically suppressing them through reproductive pedagogies. The article's positioning of these as exclusively adult characteristics reveals how andragogy wrongly assumes children lack agency, curiosity, and internal motivation, when the real issue is that traditional schooling destroys these qualities.

Despite its applications across professional contexts, Chan's article reveals how andragogy often functions as workforce training disguised as adult education theory. The focus on skill acquisition, job performance, and career advancement aligns perfectly with neoliberal capitalism's need for atomized, self-directed workers who internalize responsibility for their own success or failure without structural analysis. This positions andragogy not as liberatory education but as a technology for producing compliant knowledge workers.

Olmanson et al.: Taxonomy of Learning with Generative AI

Olmanson and colleagues develop a taxonomy categorizing how students use generative AI in course-related independent learning (CRIL), ranging from "Escape" (avoiding tasks) through "Help Me Learn," "Feedback Please," "Get Me Going," and "Do It For Me" to "Magnify" (enhancing creative and ambitious work). The taxonomy emerged from interviews with graduate students and aims to provide "a structured lens for understanding how AI forms a part of students' self-management of learning rather than a system-designed intervention" (p. 2). Importantly, the framework recognizes metacognitive awareness even in behaviors labeled "Escape," acknowledging that graduate students who delegate tedious peripheral tasks to AI demonstrate strategic judgment about where to invest cognitive effort. The taxonomy is explicitly positioned as diagnostic rather than prescriptive—a tool for reflection rather than behavior management. The authors note that "our data show a spectrum of cognitive engagement with generative AI, highlighting the need for explicit learning-with-AI education to engender both strategic and ethical use" (p. 14).

Key Quote: "Less attention has been paid to learner-initiated uses of AI for learning" (p. 2). This observation frames the taxonomy's intervention—shifting focus from institutional AI deployment to students' own practices. Another critical quote emphasizes the framework's pragmatic goals: "The value of a taxonomy is grounded in the identification, systematic differentiation, and naming of observed phenomena offering analytic nuance in a linguistically parsimonious package" (p. 4). This captures the taxonomy's utility as scaffolding for educators and students still developing fluency with AI integration.

The taxonomy's strength lies in its diagnostic potential. When many students cluster in "Escape Level 1" (exhausted, low-energy avoidance), this signals systemic issues—course design problems, inadequate support structures, or unsustainable workload—rather than student moral failure. The framework includes prompts for instructor reflection, asking which assignments students perceive as busywork. This positions the taxonomy as a tool for examining teaching practice, not just policing student behavior. However, the framework still operates within instructor-defined goals and

timelines, raising questions about how much self-direction actually exists when the broader structures remain unchanged.

Bertram: Agile Learning Design

Bertram's article introduces Agile methodologies—imported from software development into educational contexts—as a framework for adult learning and instructional design. Agile emphasizes iterative planning, regular check-ins, incremental feedback, and time-boxed work periods called "sprints." The article positions these practices as relevant to adult education, particularly in professional development and workforce training contexts. Bertram acknowledges the specialized terminology (sprint, backlog, velocity, retrospective) while claiming these concepts shouldn't intimidate readers, though this raises questions about why such jargon persists when plain language would suffice. The framework includes defined roles (Scrum Master, Product Owner) and ritualized meeting structures (daily standups, sprint planning, retrospectives) that systematize collaboration around productivity optimization.

Our discussions revealed significant tensions between Agile's corporate origins and liberatory educational goals. Agile serves management interests in extracting maximum productivity from workers—measuring velocity, optimizing output per sprint, and treating retrospectives as brief emotional processing before continuing the grind. The inclusion of Agile in adult education readings demonstrates how "adult learning" often reduces to workforce training, with efficiency and measurable performance taking precedence over critical consciousness, collective liberation, or structural transformation. As we discussed, you could theoretically use some surface-level Agile practices (timeboxing, regular reflection) in a Freirean study circle, but you'd need to completely gut the productivity optimization language and reorient everything toward collective liberation rather than deliverables.

The fundamental question becomes: who does this framework serve? Unlike the Olmanson taxonomy, which helps learners make strategic choices about cognitive labor, Agile serves organizational efficiency. The specialized vocabulary functions as gatekeeping, creating a professional class of certified consultants while wrapping ordinary collaborative practices in corporate mystique. When positioned alongside readings on andragogy and decolonizing education, Agile exemplifies the vocational/economic logics that constrain adult education discourse, revealing how liberation-oriented pedagogies must actively resist capture by productivity frameworks.

Synthesis: Decolonizing Adult Learning

Across these Week 11 readings, a central tension emerges between liberatory visions of adult learning and the persistent reduction of "adult education" to workforce development and productivity optimization. Loeng's historical analysis reveals that andragogy has multiple genealogies—European traditions focused on social healing and collective wellbeing versus Knowles's American framework centered on individual self-actualization and career advancement. The colonial dimensions of Knowles's approach become visible when we recognize how he universalized white, Western, middle-class values (individualism, self-direction, independence) as natural human characteristics rather than culturally specific ideals.

serving particular economic systems. As one critique cited by Loeng notes, Knowles "presupposed that all humans and cultures valued ideals such as individualism, self-realisation, independence, and self-direction"—the classic colonial move of presenting particular values as universal while erasing other ways of knowing and being.

The false dichotomy between pedagogy and andragogy proves especially problematic from a Freirean perspective. Knowles needed pedagogy to be the villain—authoritarian, teacher-centered, treating learners as empty vessels—so andragogy could be the hero. But this strawman obscures how both children and adults deserve education oriented toward liberation rather than domestication. The qualities Knowles attributes exclusively to adult learners—self-direction, internal motivation, using experience as a resource—are innate tendencies in children that reproductive pedagogies systematically destroy. As we discussed, "You know how we get adults like that? Because we foster and encourage those innate tendencies in our kids!" The distinction isn't between child and adult learning (kind) but rather different developmental contexts and power relations (degree). Liberatory pedagogies apply across ages, with contextual adjustments for developmental stage and lived experience.

The Olmanson taxonomy and Bertram's Agile framework provide contrasting examples of how we might evaluate educational tools and frameworks. Both are expert-defined structures offering language and categories for practice. Yet their purposes and effects differ dramatically. The AI taxonomy serves learners navigating new technological possibilities, providing scaffolding for reflection without demanding compliance. It explicitly acknowledges that graduate students who delegate tedious work to AI demonstrate metacognitive awareness and strategic judgment—reframing "Escape Level 2" as potentially legitimate resistance to busywork rather than moral failure. The taxonomy's diagnostic potential makes course design problems visible, prompting instructors to examine their own practice. Agile, conversely, serves organizational efficiency and productivity measurement. Its jargon functions as gatekeeping, and its rituals (sprints, standups, retrospectives) systematize collaboration around deliverables and velocity rather than critical consciousness or collective transformation.

This distinction matters immensely. As we discussed: "AI taxonomy: 'Here are different ways students engage with AI in their learning. Some might be more strategic than others, but let's understand the full range and help people make conscious choices about where they invest their cognitive effort.' Agile: 'Here's how to organize your work so we can measure your velocity and maximize output per sprint. Don't worry, we have retrospectives where you can talk about feelings before we do it all again next sprint.' One is about agency and metacognition. The other is about productivity metrics dressed up as collaboration." When "adult learning" reduces to workforce training, tools like Agile make perfect sense—they're efficient, measurable, performance-enhancing. But from a liberatory education perspective, where learning concerns conscientization and transformation, Agile becomes another mechanism of control.

The Nottingham Andragogy Group's Freirean-influenced definition offers an alternative trajectory: andragogy as "enabling people to become aware that they should be the originators of their own thinking and feeling." This shifts from Knowles's individualistic self-actualization toward something closer to

conscientization—the development of critical consciousness through praxis. However, even this more promising definition requires interrogation. Is identity formation truly sequential—first know yourself, then participate in community? Or is knowing yourself dialectical, emerging through and with community, as in Freirean dialogue or Anzaldúa's borderlands consciousness? The liberatory move isn't creating yourself ex nihilo but refusing to have identity, reality, and understanding imposed upon you—becoming an active participant in collective meaning-making rather than a passive recipient of predetermined narratives.

Ultimately, this Week 11 material demonstrates that terminology matters less than the power relations and purposes embedded within frameworks. "Adult education" versus "andragogy," "sprint" versus "focused work period," "self-directed learning" versus "learner agency"—the specific words hold less importance than whose interests they serve and what possibilities they foreclose or enable. The question isn't whether to adopt andragogy or reject it, but rather: Does this framework help us build toward collective liberation, or does it domesticate us into existing oppressive structures? Does it naturalize particular cultural values as universal, or does it make visible the colonial genealogies and power dynamics shaping educational discourse? Can we use its tools for liberatory purposes, or is it so embedded in reproductive logics that resistance requires building alternative infrastructures entirely?

These readings reveal adult education as a contested terrain. European andragogical traditions emerging from trauma and social healing exist alongside American frameworks serving individual career advancement and corporate productivity. Taxonomies that support learner agency coexist with management methodologies that optimize worker output. Liberation-oriented definitions inspired by Freire compete with vocational training models. The challenge becomes navigating this terrain strategically—recognizing when frameworks offer useful scaffolding versus when they encode domination, knowing when to appropriate tools for subversive purposes versus when to reject them entirely, understanding that the same language ("self-direction," "adult learning," "collaboration") can serve radically different political projects depending on context and application.